

Abies balsamea (Pinaceae)

Balsam Fir

Description Conical evergreen tree growing to 90 ft (27 m). Has aromatic needle-like leaves and purple fir cones.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, balsam fir is commercially grown for its timber. The resin is tapped from 60- to 80-year-old trees in spring.

Parts Used Oleoresin, leaves.

Constituents Balsam fir leaves contain a liquid oleoresin.

History & Folklore Balsam fir resin, often known as Canada balsam, was used for many illnesses by both Native Americans and settlers. The Penobscot smeared the resin on burns, cuts, and sores, while others applied it to the chest and back for colds and chest problems. The Pillagers used the aromatic needles in their sweat lodges, inhaling smoke from the burning leaves. Dr. Wooster Beech (1794–1868), founder of the Eclectic healing movement, regarded balsam fir as stimulating and axative when taken internally, and emollient and cooling when used externally. Balsam fir leaves, cones, and resin are commonly added to potpourri.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Balsam fir is antiseptic and stimulant, and has been used in North America and Europe for congestion, chest infections such as bronchitis, and urinary tract conditions such as cystitis and frequent urination. Externally, balsam fir was rubbed on the chest or applied as a plaster for respiratory infections. It is not used much in herbal medicine today.

Abrus precatorius (Fabaceae)

Jequirity

Description Deciduous climber growing to 12 ft (4 m). Has compound leaves, clusters of pink flowers, and seed pods containing scarlet or (rarely) white seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Jequirity is native to India, and now grows in hedges and among bushes in all tropical regions.

Parts Used Root, leaves, seeds.

Constituents Jequirity seeds contain abrin, indole alkaloids, triterpenoid saponins, and anthocyanins. The root and leaves contain glycyrrhizin and traces of abrin. Abrin is extremely toxic.

History & Folklore Jequirity seeds have been used since ancient times in India to help weigh precious materials, including the famous Koh-i-noor diamond. The seeds are notorious as a poison.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Jequirity seeds have been used medicinally in the past as a

contraceptive, abortifacient (to induce a miscarriage), and as a treatment for chronic conjunctivitis. However, they are so poisonous that even external application can be fatal. In laboratory experiments, extracts of the seeds had a strong antifertility effect on sperm production and fertility. The ground root is traditionally taken to treat worm infestation.

⚠️ Cautions Never use the seeds. Use the leaves and roots only under professional supervision. Jequirity is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Jequirity seeds were used medicinally in former times, but are also extremely poisonous.

Abutilon indicum (Malvaceae)

Kanghi, Indian Mallow

Description Upright, woody shrub growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has a downy, slightly oily surface, single yellow flowers, and kidney-shaped seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Kanghi grows throughout much of India in addition to Southeast Asia.

Parts Used Root, bark, leaves, seeds.

Constituents Kanghi contains mucilage, tannins, and asparagine. Asparagine is diuretic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Also known as Indian mallow, kanghi is used in much the same way as marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165), one of the main European demulcent herbs. The root, leaves, and bark of kanghi are mucilaginous and are used to soothe and protect the mucous membranes of the respiratory and urinary systems. A decoction of the root is given for chest conditions such as bronchitis. The mucilaginous effect benefits the skin; an infusion, poultice, or paste made from the powdered root or bark is applied to wounds and used for conditions such as boils and ulcers. A decoction of the root can also be used to good effect as a mouthwash for toothache and sore and

infected gums. The seeds are laxative and “useful in killing threadworms, if the rectum of the affected child be exposed to the smoke of the powdered seeds” (*Herbs that Heal*, H. K. Bakhrui, 1992). The plant has an antiseptic effect within the urinary tract.

Related Species *A. trisulcatum*, native to Central America, is used to treat asthma in children, and is applied as a poultice for treating cancerous sores and ulcers, especially of the mouth and cervix.

Acacia catechu syn. Senegalia catechu (Fabaceae)

Black Catechu, Cutch

Description Tree growing to 49 ft (15 m) with thorny branches and divided, feathery leaves.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India, Myanmar (Burma), Sri Lanka, and East Africa, this tree is cultivated for its timber. It grows to altitudes of 4,900 ft (1,500 m).

Parts Used Bark, heartwood, leaves, shoots.

Constituents The shiny, black-brown extract of leaves and young shoots, which is called “cutch,” becomes a brittle solid when dried, and is the form in which black catechu is generally sold. Cutch contains 25–60% tannins, 20–30% mucilage, flavonoids, and resins.



Black catechu is an astringent and antiseptic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Black catechu is a strong astringent and clotting agent. It helps reduce excess mucus in the nose, the large intestine, or vagina. It is also used to treat eczema, hemorrhages, diarrhea, and dysentery. It may be used as an infusion, tincture, powder, or ointment. A small piece of cutch dissolved in the mouth is an excellent remedy for bleeding gums and canker sores. The powder and tincture